

TECHNICAL WHITEPAPER

The ID's Guide to WCAG 2.2 for Government Programs

How Instructional Designers Can Lead the Shift from Section 508 to WCAG 2.2 — and Turn Compliance Into a Competitive Advantage

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Executive Summary

The U.S. Access Board updated its Section 508 technical standard to incorporate WCAG 2.1 Level AA in 2018. As agencies and contractors now begin adopting WCAG 2.2, instructional designers have a rare strategic window: be the expert in the room before the auditors arrive.

WCAG 2.2, published by the W3C in October 2023, introduces nine new or revised success criteria with direct impact on federal e-learning, training portals, and digital job aids. For government contractors and federal agencies, the update represents both a compliance obligation and a market differentiator.

This whitepaper provides instructional designers with:

- A plain-language breakdown of every WCAG 2.2 change that affects e-learning and training content
- A mapping of Section 508 requirements to WCAG 2.2 success criteria
- A prioritized implementation roadmap sized for real project timelines
- A ready-to-use compliance checklist for QA review
- Guidance on turning 508/WCAG expertise into a front-page differentiator for government contracting

1. Why WCAG 2.2 — and Why Now?

1.1 The Regulatory Landscape

Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act requires federal agencies and their contractors to ensure that electronic and information technology is accessible to people with disabilities. The 2018 refresh brought Section 508 into alignment with WCAG 2.0 Level AA — but the web accessibility standard did not stop there.

WCAG 2.2 was finalized in October 2023. While the Access Board has not yet issued a formal refresh mandating WCAG 2.2, agency solicitations are already referencing it in technical requirements. Contractors who wait for a mandate to begin learning will be behind.

1.2 The Government Contractor's Risk

Non-compliance with accessibility standards carries concrete risks for contractors:

- Contract disqualification during technical evaluation

- Remediation costs that dwarf the cost of building it right the first time (industry average: 5–10× more expensive to fix post-delivery)
- Civil rights complaints filed with the agency or directly with OCR
- Reputational damage in a market where small businesses compete on past performance

Key data point: The Department of Justice's 2023 Web Accessibility Guidance and Executive Order 14035 on Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility signal that WCAG 2.2 compliance will be a standard contract expectation within the next 18–24 months.

2. Section 508 vs. WCAG 2.2: Understanding the Relationship

The relationship between Section 508, WCAG 2.1, and WCAG 2.2 confuses many practitioners. Here is a clear framework:

Standard	Published	Required By Law?	Relationship
Section 508 (2018 Refresh)	January 2018	Yes — federal agencies & contractors	Mandates WCAG 2.0 Level AA
WCAG 2.1 Level AA	June 2018	Via Section 508 / state laws	Adds 12 criteria to WCAG 2.0
WCAG 2.2 Level AA	October 2023	Emerging — agency RFPs now cite it	Adds 9 criteria to WCAG 2.1

For practical purposes: if you build to WCAG 2.2 Level AA, you automatically satisfy WCAG 2.1 and WCAG 2.0 requirements as well, because the standards are additive. This makes WCAG 2.2 compliance the single safest target for any government-facing training deliverable.

3. The 9 WCAG 2.2 Changes — What They Mean for Training Content

WCAG 2.2 introduces six new success criteria at Level A and AA, revises two existing criteria, and removes one. Below is each change translated into instructional design terms.

3.1 Focus Appearance (2.4.11 / 2.4.12) — AA & AAA

Keyboard focus indicators must now meet minimum size and contrast requirements. The visible focus ring must be at least 2 CSS pixels wide and surround the component, with a 3:1 contrast ratio against adjacent colors.

ID Impact: Any custom Articulate Storyline or Rise interactions that suppress or restyle the browser's default focus outline must be audited. Learners who navigate by keyboard — a requirement in many government facilities where mice are not permitted on classified networks — must be able to see exactly where focus is.

Action: Test every clickable element in your SCORM package using Tab navigation only. If you cannot see a clear, high-contrast ring, the component fails.

3.2 Dragging Movements (2.5.7) — AA

Any functionality that uses a dragging motion (drag-and-drop matching activities, sortable lists) must also be achievable through a single pointer action without dragging.

ID Impact: Drag-to-match and sequencing activities are popular in government onboarding courses. Every drag interaction needs a click-based or keyboard alternative. This is a common gap in older SCORM 1.2 content being repurposed for new contracts.

3.3 Target Size (Minimum) (2.5.8) — AA

Interactive targets must be at least 24×24 CSS pixels. This replaces the old AAA-level 44×44px guideline with a more practical AA-level floor.

ID Impact: Small radio buttons, checkbox rows, and navigation arrows in Rise or Storyline templates often fall below this threshold. Audit interactive elements on mobile-rendered content especially — government learners on CAC-enabled tablets need adequately sized targets.

3.4 Consistent Help (3.2.6) — A

If a help mechanism (chatbot, help link, phone number, contact form) appears across multiple pages, it must appear in the same relative location on each page.

ID Impact: For multi-module LMS courses with a persistent help or support link in the header or footer, that element must not shift position between modules. Navigation templates should be locked and audited for consistency.

3.5 Redundant Entry (3.3.7) — A

Information previously entered by the user must be auto-populated or available to select when re-entry is required in the same session.

ID Impact: Courses with multi-page forms, registration flows, or learner-profile capture screens must not force the same data to be re-entered. Government systems that capture PII during training enrollment are common candidates for this issue.

3.6 Accessible Authentication — Minimum & Enhanced (3.3.8 / 3.3.9) — AA & AAA

Authentication steps that require solving a cognitive function test (such as transcribing distorted text, solving a puzzle, or remembering a password without assistance) must offer an accessible alternative.

ID Impact: Government LMS portals that use image-based CAPTCHAs or require learners to identify objects as part of login are directly affected. This criterion also affects course-embedded authentication gates or scenario simulations that mimic login screens.

3.7 Revision to 2.4.7: Focus Visible

WCAG 2.2 strengthens the language of the existing Focus Visible criterion. In prior versions the requirement was vague enough that a barely-visible 1-pixel dotted line could pass. WCAG 2.2 tightens the expectation to align with the new Focus Appearance criteria above.

3.8 Removal: 4.1.1 Parsing

WCAG 2.2 removes the Parsing success criterion (4.1.1), which required clean, error-free HTML markup. Modern browsers have become sophisticated enough at error recovery that this criterion was largely redundant. This is the one area where WCAG 2.2 reduces burden — though clean markup remains best practice.

4. Implementation Roadmap

Use this three-phase roadmap to bring a government training program from current Section 508 / WCAG 2.1 compliance to full WCAG 2.2 Level AA conformance.

Phase 1 — Audit & Inventory (Weeks 1–2)

- Catalog all course assets: SCORM packages, Rise exports, PDF job aids, video files, LMS pages
- Run automated scan with axe DevTools or WAVE on all HTML-based content
- Document manual test results: keyboard navigation, screen reader (NVDA + Chrome), zoom to 400%
- Score each module against the WCAG 2.2 checklist (see Section 5)
- Prioritize remediation by learner impact and contract deliverable timeline

Phase 2 — Remediation (Weeks 3–6)

- Fix focus indicators: update custom CSS / Storyline themes to meet 2px / 3:1 contrast spec
- Replace all drag-only interactions with click/keyboard alternatives
- Enlarge all interactive targets to minimum 24×24px
- Standardize help link placement across all templates
- Eliminate redundant data entry across multi-page course flows
- Update alt text, captions, and transcripts to current WCAG standards
- Validate fixes with both automated tools and manual screen reader walkthrough

Phase 3 — Documentation & Delivery (Week 7+)

- Produce a Voluntary Product Accessibility Template (VPAT) for each deliverable
- Include accessibility conformance statement in course footers and LMS metadata
- Deliver remediation summary report to contracting officer
- Train client LMS administrators on ongoing accessibility QA process
- Schedule annual re-audit as part of contract maintenance

5. WCAG 2.2 QA Checklist for Government Training Content

Use this checklist during development QA and final review. Print and sign for inclusion in deliverable documentation packages.

#	Criterion	Level	Pass / Fail
1	All keyboard-navigable elements have a visible focus indicator $\geq 2\text{px}$ wide with 3:1 contrast	AA	
2	All dragging interactions have a single-pointer (click) alternative	AA	
3	All interactive targets meet minimum 24×24px size	AA	
4	Help mechanism (if present) appears in consistent location across all pages	A	
5	No information previously entered is required to be re-entered in the same session	A	
6	Authentication does not require solving a cognitive puzzle without an alternative	AA	
7	All images have meaningful alt text (or empty alt for decorative)	A	
8	All video content has synchronized captions	A	
9	All video content has audio description or transcript	AA	
10	Color is not the only means of conveying information	A	
11	Text contrast ratio is at least 4.5:1 (large text: 3:1)	AA	
12	Content reflows to single column at 400% zoom without horizontal scrolling	AA	
13	All form inputs have programmatically associated labels	A	
14	Error messages identify the field and describe the correction needed	A	
15	Page/course language is set in HTML lang attribute	A	
16	Navigation order is logical and matches visual presentation	A	
17	VPAT completed and included in deliverable package	N/A	

6. Common Pitfalls in Government E-Learning Accessibility

⚠ Relying on automated scanners alone

Automated tools catch roughly 30–40% of accessibility issues. Dragging alternatives, focus visibility, target size, and cognitive load cannot be detected by axe or WAVE without manual testing. Plan at least two hours of manual testing per course module.

⚠ Retrofitting instead of building in

Accessibility bolted on after development typically costs 5–10× more than designing for it from the start. Include accessibility review gates at storyboard, prototype, and beta stages — not only at final QA.

⚠ Treating VPAT as a checkbox document

A Voluntary Product Accessibility Template (VPAT) is a legal conformance claim. Contracting officers and CO/CORs are increasingly asking for supporting test evidence. Maintain a test log alongside your VPAT.

⚠ Ignoring the LMS wrapper

The Storyline or Rise output may be fully accessible, but the LMS iframe wrapper, course launcher, or progress-tracking page may fail independently. Test the full learner journey, not just the SCORM package in isolation.

⚠ Missing the PDF job aid

Training packages almost always include PDF job aids, facilitator guides, or reference cards. These are governed by the same 508/WCAG standards as interactive content and are frequently overlooked. Use Adobe Acrobat's accessibility checker and apply logical reading order, tagged headings, and alt text to all figures.

7. Turning Compliance Into a Competitive Advantage

Most contractors treat WCAG compliance as a cost center. The instructional designers who understand it as a capability differentiator win more work and command higher rates.

7.1 What to Lead With in Proposals

When responding to government RFPs, include a dedicated Accessibility Approach section even if it is not explicitly required. Describe your:

- WCAG 2.2 Level AA design standards
- Authoring tool configuration (Articulate Storyline / Rise accessibility settings)
- QA process: automated scan + manual keyboard + screen reader
- VPAT delivery with each course module
- Remediation SLA if post-delivery issues are identified

7.2 Building a Repeatable Accessible Template Library

The single highest-ROI investment for a government-focused ID is a library of pre-audited Storyline and Rise templates that pass WCAG 2.2 by default. This reduces per-module development time, eliminates last-minute remediation scrambles, and gives you a concrete asset to reference in proposals.

7.3 The Federal Section 508 Opportunity

Federal agencies and their contractors produce annual compliance, security, and technical training at scale. Demonstrated WCAG 2.2 expertise positions an instructional designer as a preferred subcontractor or sole-source candidate for rapid-turn compliance training updates when regulations change.

Positioning statement for your LinkedIn / capability statement: "Section 508-native instructional designer specializing in WCAG 2.2-compliant e-learning for federal agencies and government contractors."

8. Next Steps

Whether you are assessing an existing course library, preparing a proposal, or building a new program from scratch, the path to WCAG 2.2 compliance is straightforward when you have an experienced partner.

Ready to Assess Your Training Content?

I offer a free 30-minute accessibility consultation for government contractors looking to understand their current WCAG compliance posture and where to start.

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